President Obama was quoted as saying that he might not agree with every aspect of the proposal but that it took great courage to put forward something so significant.

Brent Scowcroft and Zbigniew Brzezinski, who at various times had served as US national security advisers, wrote that the major elements of such an agreement were well known and that the US president ought to declare publicly that the basic parameters of a fair peace should contain the following four principal elements: 1967 borders, with minor, reciprocal and agreed-upon modifications; compensation in lieu of the “right of return” for Palestinian refugees; Jerusalem as the capital of the two peoples; and a demilitarized Palestinian state. In addition, something more might be needed to deal with Israeli security concerns, which a Palestinian government would be incapable of providing. This could be dealt with by deploying an international peacekeeping force, such as one from NATO.

The well-known journalist Thomas Friedman complained that the Arab League did not know how to properly “sell” the proposal. According to him, King Abdullah of Saudi Arabia should have flown to Israel (as Sadat had) and make four stops: the Al Aksa Mosque in East Jerusalem; Ramallah, where he could address the Palestinian parliament; Yad Vashem, and finally the Knesset—the Israeli parliament—where he could formally deliver his peace initiative.

Ban Ki-moon was quoted as saying that the Arab League initiative sent a clear signal that the Arab world, too, craved peace.

The almost automatic negative Israeli response can be explained by the Israeli interpretation of the proposal as “take it or leave it” and by the fact that it mentioned UN Resolution 194 in the context of the refugee issue. The last point that bothered the Israelis was that according to the proposal Israel would receive the promised changes only after it fulfilled its part. However, it should be noted that in the various rounds of negotiations that have taken place between the parties since 2002, quite a few elements of the Arab League’s proposal have been softened. On the territorial issue, the component of land swaps was added, as well as the Palestinian consent to the settlement blocs remaining in the territories under Israeli sovereignty, in exchange for appropriate territorial compensation. The Palestinians have relaxed their position on the refugee issue relative to the wording in the League’s proposal, and they have also shown signs of willingness to be